

Surgery: What to Expect

WARWIKI

Patient Information · A general guide to preparing for and recovering from surgery

This is a general guide to what happens around the time of a urologic or pelvic-floor surgery — how to prepare, what the day of surgery is like, and what recovery involves. Your own procedure has its own handout with specific details; use this alongside it to know what to expect overall.

Getting Ready (Before Surgery)

- **Pre-op visit & tests** — you may have bloodwork, a urine test, and a review of your health and medicines.
- **Medicines** — your team will tell you which to stop and when, especially **blood thinners** and certain diabetes medicines.
- **Fasting** — usually nothing to eat or drink after midnight (or as instructed) before anesthesia.
- **Don't smoke** — even stopping a few weeks before helps healing.
- **Plan ahead** — arrange a ride, time off, and help at home.

Anesthesia

Depending on the operation, you may have **general anesthesia** (fully asleep), **spinal/regional** (numb from the waist down), or **local with sedation**. The anesthesia team will review your options and keep you safe and comfortable.

LEARN THE TERMS

Pre-op

The preparation and visits before surgery.

NPO / fasting

Nothing to eat or drink before anesthesia.

Blood thinners

Medicines that must often be paused before surgery.

General anesthesia

Medicine that keeps you fully asleep and pain-free.

Regional / spinal

Numbing the lower half of the body.

Catheter

A tube that may drain the bladder for a time after surgery.

Recovery (PACU)

The area where you wake up and are watched after surgery.

HOW LONG IS RECOVERY? It depends on the operation — from same-day home with a few days' rest, to a hospital stay and several weeks of limited activity. Your specific handout and surgeon will give your timeline. A common rule after pelvic surgery is to avoid heavy lifting and sex for about 6 weeks.

The Day of Surgery

- 1 You check in, change, and meet your surgical and anesthesia teams; an IV is placed.
- 2 You receive **antibiotics** and measures to prevent blood clots.
- 3 The surgery is performed; you wake in the **recovery area**.
- 4 You go home the same day or to a hospital room, depending on the procedure.

Recovery (After Surgery)

- **Pain control** — usually a mix of non-opioid and, if needed, short-term stronger medicine.
- **Activity** — walk early to prevent clots; ease back gradually.
- **Catheter/drains** — you may go home with one for a short time, with care instructions.
- **Bowel care** — keep stools soft to avoid straining.

Call your care team or seek care for:

- **Fever or chills**, or growing redness/drainage at an incision
- Heavy bleeding, or you **cannot urinate**
- **Chest pain, trouble breathing, or a swollen, painful leg** (possible clot) — emergency
- Severe or worsening pain, or persistent vomiting

Good to Know

- Bring a list of your medicines and allergies.
- Set up easy meals, loose clothing, and supplies before the day.

THREE THINGS TO REMEMBER

1. Prepare by following your medicine and fasting instructions, not smoking, and arranging a ride and help at home.
2. Anesthesia keeps you safe and pain-free; you'll wake in recovery and go home or to a room based on the surgery.
3. Walk early, control pain, and ease back gradually. Seek emergency care for chest pain, trouble breathing, or a swollen painful leg.